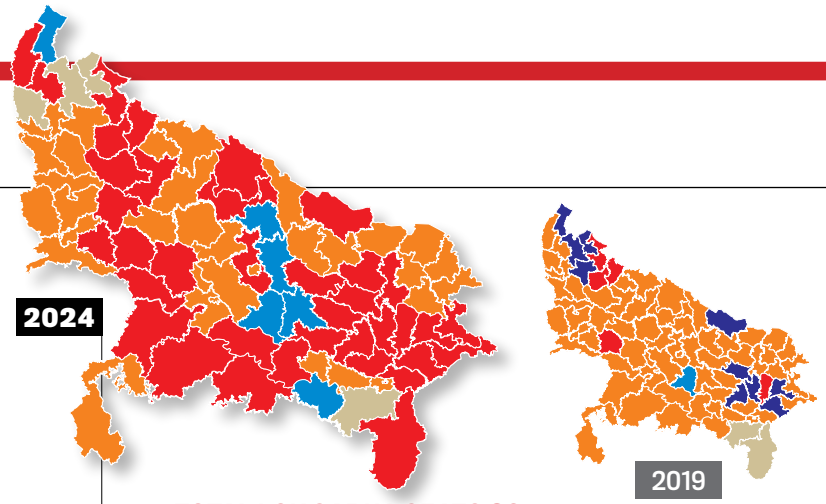


TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 80

	BJP	SP	CONG	BSP	REST
2024	33 (41.5%)	37 (33.6%)	6 (9.5%)	0 (9.4%)	4 (-)
2019	62 (50%)	5 (18.1%)	1 (6.4%)	10 (19.4%)	2 (-)

In 2024, SP and Congress were in alliance and in 2019, SP and BSP fought together; vote share in ( )



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him consolidate his grip by electing 62 party candidates, along with two of ally Apna Dal (S). This time, UP was meant to set the ball rolling for an even larger mandate, but that was not to be. Prime Minister Modi's own victory margin of 152,513 votes in Varanasi—less than a third of the 479,000-odd he got in 2019—was prime evidence of how the BJP had lost the plot in UP.

SAFFRON GETS A SHOCK

Of the 12 members of the Union cabinet who contested again in UP, only five managed a return ticket to Parliament, among them PM Modi and defence minister Rajnath Singh. The list of those who fell by the wayside includes Smriti Irani in Amethi, Ajay Mishra Teni (whose son allegedly mowed down four people during the anti-farm laws protest) in Kheri and Sanjeev Balyan (an accused in the 2013 riots) in Muzaffarnagar. Irani's defeat summed up the anti-BJP sentiment in some seats. She lost to Gandhi family loyalist Kishori Lal Sharma—who had been informed he was contesting just a day before the nominations—by over 167,000 votes.

But nothing could beat the loss in the Faizabad Lok Sabha seat, where Lord Ram seems to have deserted the BJP, despite the spectacular opening of a grand temple in his name in Ayodha in January. Having come good on a promise that was part of the manifesto in the previous election, the BJP had hoped to bask in the glory of its inauguration, and use it to set the tone for the national poll campaign. But the sureshot win the party candidate in Faizabad, two-time MP Lallu Singh, had hoped for turned into a loss against the SP's Awadhesh Prasad, a nine-time MLA and one of the party's key Dalit faces, by over 54,500 votes. Incidentally, Lallu was one of the BJP leaders who had talked up the need for the party to go *char sau paar* so that it could "change the Constitution".

The saffron party also suffered heavy losses in western UP, despite its alliance with the regional Jat powerhouse, the Jayant Chaudhury-led Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). Of the 26 seats in the region, the NDA managed to win just 13 (five less than in 2019). Though the RLD won its two seats—Bijnor and Baghpat—the party, it seems, failed to deliver for the BJP in the region, especially in Muzaffarnagar and Kairana. This could create friction in the alliance especially as Balyan, the losing candidate in Muzaffarnagar, is said to be fuming. Another big result from the sugar belt was the victory of Chandrashekhar Azad of the fledgling Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) in the Nagina seat reserved for the Scheduled Castes. Even INDIA had dumped Azad, yet he won against all odds, taking on and beating the biggies as well as Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP).

Losing in Faizabad, where it had inaugurated the Ram temple in Ayodhya, has demonstrated the limited appeal of the communal vote

WHAT WORKED, WHAT DIDN'T

While the BJP registered its biggest loss since 2014, the SP ended up as the biggest gainer, both in seats (37) and vote share (33.6 per cent). The Congress also increased its tally from one to six seats this time. The game-changer has been Akhilesh's PDA (Pichhda, Dalit and Alpasankhyak) narrative and ticket distribution. The SP, which has always been known as the M-Y (Muslim-Yadav) party, borrowed the social engineering concept from the BJP and beat them at their own game. The party gave tickets to only five Yadavs (all Akhilesh family members) and four Muslims in a list of 62 candidates. Of the others, 10 were Kurmis and six from the Kushwaha-Maurya-Shakya-Saini castes (who had turned to the BJP as a refuge during the years of Yadav dominance). Its decision to field Dalit candidates in Meerut and Faizabad also paid off, while the alliance with the Congress was vital in enabling the Dalits to shift their votes to the SP, a party they had avoided since the '90s. Crucially, this even included Jatavs, hitherto solidly loyal to Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party